

# Delegate's Notebook

The Confederation Congress · 1786

DELEGATES

OUR STATE

DATE

Fill one box in after each vote. Two lines is plenty.

## 1 Paying the War Debt

NEEDS 9 OF 13

Our state voted:

YES NO ABSTAIN

Did it pass?

YES NO

CONGRESS ASKED FOR

CONGRESS ACTUALLY GOT

Congress voted yes. Why did the money still not arrive?

*Congress could only ask the states for money. There was no president to collect it and no court to punish a state that ignored the request, so states voted yes and then sent nothing.*

## 2 The Trade War

NEEDS 9 OF 13

Our state voted:

YES NO ABSTAIN

Did it pass?

YES NO

New York taxed goods heading to its neighbours. What could Congress actually do about it?

*Almost nothing. Congress had no power over trade, so all it could do was politely ask New York to stop. Even passing the resolution changed nothing.*

## 3 The Import Tax Amendment

NEEDS ALL 13

Our state voted:

YES NO ABSTAIN

Did it pass?

YES NO

How many states voted yes? \_\_\_\_\_ How many were needed? \_\_\_\_\_

Which state or states blocked it, and why would they not agree?

*Usually Rhode Island. It made money from its own port taxes and refused to hand the power to tax to Congress. In real life Rhode Island blocked this exact plan in 1782, alone.*

## 4 Shays' Rebellion

NEEDS 9 OF 13

Our state voted:

YES NO ABSTAIN

Did it pass?

YES NO

CONGRESS ASKED FOR

CONGRESS ACTUALLY GOT

Armed men were marching on an arsenal. Why couldn't Congress just send an army?

*Congress had no army of its own and could not draft a single soldier. It could only ask the states for men and money. In real life a private army paid for by Boston merchants stopped the rebellion.*

# What we learned

Fill this in during the debrief

## 1. The six weaknesses

write the round where you saw each one

| WEAKNESS OF THE ARTICLES                          | ROUND I SAW IT | WHAT HAPPENED                          |
|---------------------------------------------------|----------------|----------------------------------------|
| Congress could not tax — <i>it could only ask</i> | 1, 4           | <i>Voted yes, money never came</i>     |
| Congress could not control trade                  | 2              | <i>NY taxed its neighbours anyway</i>  |
| There was no president                            | 1, 2, 4        | <i>Nobody to enforce anything</i>      |
| There were no national courts                     | 2              | <i>No judge to settle state fights</i> |
| Changing the rules needed all 13                  | 3              | <i>One state killed the fix</i>        |
| Congress had no army                              | 4              | <i>Could not stop the rebellion</i>    |

## 2. What the Articles actually got right

it was not all failure

**WORD BANK — USE EACH ONCE**  
won the war · new states · slavery · king · themselves

- a. The Articles held the country together long enough that we \_\_\_\_\_ *won the war* and made peace with Britain.
- b. The Northwest Ordinance let western land become \_\_\_\_\_ *new states*, equal to the original thirteen rather than ruled by them.
- c. That same law banned \_\_\_\_\_ *slavery* in the whole Northwest Territory.
- d. There was no \_\_\_\_\_ *king*, and states kept the right to govern \_\_\_\_\_ *themselves*.

## 3. The two numbers that matter

| CONGRESS ASKED FOR, IN TOTAL | CONGRESS ACTUALLY RECEIVED | THAT IS WHAT PERCENT? |
|------------------------------|----------------------------|-----------------------|
| _____                        | _____                      | _____                 |

In real life Congress asked for about \$15 million between 1781 and 1786 and received about \$2.5 million — roughly **one dollar in six**.

## 4. Think about it

- a. Your state probably scored well by refusing to pay. So why did the country end up worse off?  
*Every state doing the smart thing for itself added up to a country that could not pay its debts, defend itself, or settle arguments. What is good for one state is not automatically good for all thirteen.*
- b. If you could change one rule of this government, which one — and what problem would it fix?

**Exit ticket.** In one sentence: name a weakness of the Articles you felt today, and say how the Constitution fixed it.